DON'T BE OFFENSIVE

Because the meek aren't going to inherit a damn thing.

By Jeff Foss

If you're ever thrown in jail, walk up to the biggest, meanest, scariest guy in the house and punch him in the grille. He might kick the ever-living crap out of you, but your street cred will skyrocket, and the other inmates will immediately know that you are not to be trifled with. Life in corporate America is similarly brutal: Strip your office of the rosy professionalism and it's just as cutthroat as a dimly lit prison yard. So how do you avoid a metaphorical shanking? Fashion the blade yourself and stop worrying about being everybody's BFF. Here's how to turn the tables and become the asshole we always knew you could be.

Take charge of your workplace!

1 Assume the Role

Tiptoeing into a situation like a preteen shoplifting a Snickers bar will undermine your ability to dominate it. "If you squirm, you're inviting a psychological beating," says Harvey Hornstein, PhD, a professor emeritus of psychology at Columbia University. "By adopting an arrogant swagger, you become a threat, and your coworkers will watch out for you." Dressing to impress—and intimidate—is another surefire way to assert your authority. "When your peers go casual, you should go business casual," says Dave Lakhani, author of *Persuasion: The Art of Getting What You Want.* "Every guy in that office needs to know that you're one step ahead of him."

2 Mark Your Territory

If control is what you're after, it doesn't hurt to take a page from nature's book. "Silverback gorillas move into the space of less powerful males," says Peter Borchelt, PhD, an animal behaviorist, "but not vice versa." For the authentic King Kong effect, try abusing what anthropologists call proxemics. It's simple: When addressing a colleague, breach the threshold in which social interaction becomes uncomfortable (approximately four feet) and make a vaguely negative observation about his work. It doesn't matter what you say—your alarming proximity will punctuate the statement with a sharp, "Yeah, you heard me, *biatch*—what!"

3 Play for Keeps

Rules—much like coworkers' spirits—are made to be broken. And while it's important to be familiar with company policies, it's just as crucial to set yourself apart. "Don't be afraid to challenge the status quo if you have a better idea of how things should be run," says Ben Dattner, PhD, an executive coach in New York City. As long as your higher-ups see you as an asset, you shouldn't be worried about stepping on toes. "Most workers in organizations are afraid to take risks," says Dr. Robert Butterworth, a Los Angeles–based psychologist. "If you're confident, you may be able to take the contrarian approach and pull it off."

Number Crunching

Percentage who are dissatisfied with their current salary

Percentage who talk shit behind coworkers' backs

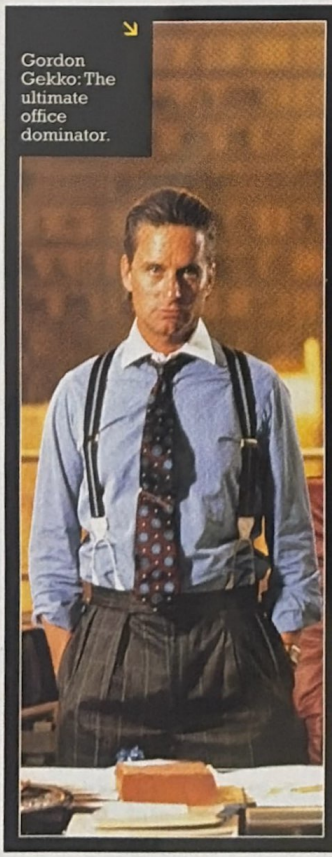
Percentage who steal office supplies from work

Percentage who fart in coworkers' cubicles

Monday
The best time to put in a vacation request

Tuesday
The best day to show off to your boss

Wednesday
The best day to demand a raise



Gordon Gekko: The ultimate office dominator.

A-Hole Evaluator

Are you the office doormat? Maybe you're not being a big enough prick. Take this test and find out if you're man enough to be successful.

Do you ever take credit for other people's ideas?
a. Never. **[0 points]**
b. Sometimes, but I feel bad afterward. **[1 point]**
c. Often, regardless of the consequences. **[2 points]**

Have you ever stolen somebody's lunch out of the company fridge?
a. No. **[0]**
b. Yes. **[2]**

Do you ever raise your voice at subordinates?
a. Never. **[0]**
b. Sometimes, but I feel bad about it afterward. **[1]**
c. Occasionally, but in private. **[2]**
d. Often, and usually in public. **[3]**

Have you ever sabotaged a colleague's work?
a. No. **[0]**
b. Yes. **[2]**

When a group of coworkers invite you to lunch, you...
a. Join them. **[0]**
b. Tell them you have work to do, even if you don't. **[1]**
c. Ask them, "Don't you slackers have work to do?" **[2]**

During business dinners, do you ever talk down to the waiter?
a. Never. **[0]**
b. Sometimes, but only when the service is poor. **[1]**
c. Often. I mean, these drinks aren't going to refill themselves, right? **[2]**
d. All the time. Those ingrates probably didn't even graduate from high school! **[3]**

If a coworker forgot to log off of his computer, would you read his e-mails?
a. No way. **[0]**
b. I might glance at them if I saw my name. **[1]**
c. Of course. If I find something suspicious, it might give me some leverage over him. **[2]**

Do you ever directly challenge coworkers at important meetings?
a. Never. **[0]**
b. Once in a while, but only to offer helpful suggestions. **[1]**
c. Only if it makes me look good in front of my boss. **[2]**
d. All the time. Shooting down people's ideas is the best way to shut them up. **[3]**

Have you ever parked in a handicapped parking spot?
a. No. **[0]**
b. Yes. **[2]**

Answer Key:
0–7 points: Remember that old saying about nice guys finishing last? We hope you like the view from back there. And no, baking brownies for the entire department isn't going to help.
8–14 points: You may not be an overbearing jerk, but you won't be winning any office popularity awards either. Wolf or sheep: It's time to step up and make the call.
15–21 points: You're a king-size SOB, and odds are you're the least-liked guy in the building. But what do you care? Let them fight for scraps while you make partner by 29.

A smattering of alpha-male dickheads from our Tinseltown favorites.

4 5 6

It Is Better to Be Feared, *Then* Loved

Machiavelli may have been a Grade A dick, but there's something to be said for his brazen self-interest. "If you're the alpha male of the office and you let your guard down," warns Hornstein, "people might try to screw you." To put the kibosh on a potential backstabbing, make sure to surprise your frightened associates with occasional gifts. This fosters what is known as Stockholm Syndrome, a term that refers to an incident in which a Swedish bank hostage fell in love with her captor. "When you're the intimidator," explains Dr. Kevin J. Fleming, a psychologist and executive coach, "a little love goes a long way."

Keep Your Enemies Close...

To become the dick-swinging Gordon Gekko of the boardroom, you'll need a loyal following. "Create an inner circle," advises Lakhani. "Draw in people you can control, people who will listen to what you say, people who might even be a little disenfranchised." Start with nearby cubicles and work your way out. As emotionally incapacitated colleagues pledge their blind allegiance to you, gradually expand your circle of influence; competitors will inevitably be drawn into the fold and forced to hand over their territory, confidence and power. "This is what cultists are good at," says Lakhani, "and it can be a very effective strategy."

...And Your Friends Nonexistent

Most people want to be liked, but appealing to the lowest common denominator isn't necessarily the best way to get ahead. "It's impossible to dominate the office if you put the focus on caring about what other people think of you," says Mark Stevens, founder and CEO of the global marketing firm MSCO. What does this mean? Don't be afraid to tell off that hopeless coworker who keeps making you look bad, and if you can, do it publicly—you want the word to spread that you mean business. "The alpha male has combat eyes," says Stevens. "He sees anybody who isn't helping him as an enemy."

Our Favorite Asshole

Scott Rudin

Hollywood is full of self-righteous jerks, but *Ransom*, *School of Rock* and *Team America: World Police* producer Scott Rudin is downright nasty: This obnoxious loose cannon explodes at the drop of a hat, makes laughably unreasonable demands ("Translate this obscure French art journal, and track down this director vacationing in the Himalayas!") and is rumored to have programmed the words "String cheese, NOW!" into the digital readout of his office phone system. What a magnificent bastard! Notoriously impossible to work for, Rudin fires people like it's his job and once cycled through 30 assistants in a span of 15 months. Quivering protégés who are lucky enough to survive his wrath do so by learning the tricks of the trade, like rearranging his desk so that when he gets angry, he can't reach anything he might use to throw at them. Here are some quotes from this alpha-male monster:

"The only thing separating my hands from your neck is the fact that there are 3,000 miles between us!"

"Learn to communicate!"

"When I ask you these questions, have an answer ready. Then I would think you're intelligent!"

"Your parents paid for you to go to college and you don't know who Fred Zinnemann is?"

Talk about a prick. We heart you, Scott Rudin!